Taliban's line" ... but that was difficult to do as we [R&AW] did not have the contacts with them [Afghan Taliban]'.[97] Unlike what X claims, India did have links with the Afghan Taliban, with the MI (and even some R&AW) officers often facilitating such links. Despite being outside their operational ambit, the MI played an important role in opening channels on the ground with various Afghan Taliban commanders.[98]

When pushed about the inconsistency between his claim and that of what other Indian officials thought about India's outreach to the Afghan Taliban, X articulated the real reason for his disaffection with Menon. 'How could you trust them [Afghan Taliban]? They were all based out of Pakistan or had families there. They held Pakistan passports, and were Pakistanis. But Menon wouldn't agree with that,' says X.[99] It was classic anti-Pakistan partisanship. Though X agreed that the Afghan Taliban was a fractured movement and Haqqanis were the most dangerous for India, he refused to accept that an open approach towards the Afghan Taliban was worthwhile. India's focus on moderate Afghan Taliban leaders such as Tayyab Agha (Quetta Shura's spokesperson), Abdal Salam Zaeef, and Muttawakil, was pointless in his opinion. Instead, he argued, even if India wanted to engage with the Afghan Taliban, it should have reached out to the likes of Agha Jan Mutasim, Mullah Omar's son-in-law, and Abdul Ghani Baradar, both of 'whom the NDS got out of Pakistan's clutches'.[100] Mutasim and Baradar had become faces of the 'moderate' Taliban factions who were willing to reconcile directly with the Afghan government. Having opposed engagement with the Taliban in the mid-1990s, X continued opposing talks with insurgent groups based out of Pakistan. Such partisanship, however, grew increasingly marginal.

In April 2010, weeks after the Hamid guesthouse attack and the London conference, Taliban spokesperson Zabiullah Mujahid publicly responded to India's evolving policy approach. In an interview with Rahimullah Yusufzai, Mujahid stated that the Taliban did not 'believe that India will seriously oppose Karzai's policy' of reconciliation and that 'if the Taliban returns to power, we would like to maintain normal relations with all countries including India. It's possible for the Taliban and India to reconcile with each other.'[101] Mujahid reiterated that India cannot be completely expelled from Afghanistan and that the Taliban had no direct conflict with India. But neither can they ignore